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Title:
Everything Under the Sun

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EVERYTHING UNDER THE SUN
By Bridget Grace Sheaff

SYNOPSIS: At an interplanetary meeting, The Sun announces that she needs a vacation. Each of the planets vies for their position as the center of the solar system, with disastrous results. In the end, after a rally of appreciation, The Sun decides to stay.

CHARACTERS:

SUN- The leader. Exhausted. Quick-witted, but sometimes lacking in leadership.
MERCURY- The brainiac. Talkative and intelligent to the point of being a real pest.
VENUS- The flirt. Very feminine. Living up to her name.
EARTH- The sassy one. Bold and brash, but loving and caring all the same. "Mother Earth."
MARS- The dark one. Deeply philosophical to a terrifying degree.
JUPITER- The jock. Not that bright. Slow. Can be a jerk, but is not aware of his own strength.
SATURN- The brawn. Authoritative, stepping out of rank. Keeps the outer planets in line.
URANUS- The clown. Constant joking, probably as a defense mechanism because of his name.
NEPTUNE- The old one. Too far away. Can't hear worth a darn.
PLUTO- The outcast. Small. Meek. But surprisingly insightful.

SCENE: A conference room, one where an interplanetary meeting is taking place.

AT RISE: The planets are sitting around chatting while SUN moves to the head of the table. JUPITER is holding MERCURY'S glasses above his head as MERCURY tries to jump and grab them. EARTH and VENUS are talking rapidly. MARS sits darkly, arms crossed. NEPTUNE is not even at the table and is sitting very far away from the rest of the group. SATURN keeps glancing at PLUTO threateningly from across the table, as if PLUTO is an insolent child. PLUTO sits complacently, staring at his hands.

SUN: Alright, alright, alright, settle down. Settle down. Jupiter, leave Mercury alone.

JUPITER: Sorry, Sun.

MERCURY: Yeah, Jupiter, why don't you bother someone with the same relative mass and mean radius as yourself?

JUPITER: … Wha?

SUN: Never mind! Never mind. Can we get this meeting started please… and keep the side conversations to a minimum? Earth, Venus, something you'd like to share with the group?

EARTH: If I wanted to share it with the group, I wouldn't have whispered it to Venus, huh? Mm-hmm.

VENUS: Sorry, sunny boy, just girl talk.

EARTH: Like I was saying before we were so rudely interrupted, craters are just part of being a planet. They're just the death of your complexion.

MARS: Death is the real killer. Death is coming. End of all we know.

SUN:… Okay then, Mars… Can we please begin? Please?

NEPTUNE: What?

SUN: (yelling) I said "can we please begin the meeting," Neptune.

NEPTUNE: What?

SUN: Oh, never mind.

PLUTO: I think…

SATURN: Pluto! What did I tell you about talking? You shouldn't even be here. You're not a planet anymore.

PLUTO: I just…

SATURN: Shush! Don't make me come over there.

URANUS: It's okay, Pluto. Saturn is a bit of a… luna-tic. Get it? Luna? Moon? Because he has so many moons? Get it?

SUN: (sarcastic) As usual, Uranus, your humor is both mature and necessary and makes us all stop and examine our humdrum lives. Can we please start? Please?

JUPITER: Yeah, uh… why are we here?

SUN: Great question, Jupiter. Great question. Let's begin. I call this meeting, finally, to order. Any old business? Mercury?

MERCURY: You'll be pleased to know that according to my calculations all orbits are going according to schedule.

VENUS: Oh, Mercury, you're so smart. What ever would we do without you?

MERCURY: Uh… I… uh…

SUN: Moving on. Any eclipses we need to know about?

MERCURY: None that we haven't already discussed.

SUN: Excellent. How is the space cleaning process going?

MERCURY: Earth's atmosphere needs clearing of excess space junk, including the Fox Satellite. The asteroid belt has been inspected and is in desperate need of cleaning.

URANUS: We don't want to lose the asteroid belt. Our pants will fall down. Get it?

VENUS: (laughs) Oh, that was funny! You're so funny!

SUN: Venus, let's keep the flirting to a minimum, okay? Any other old business?

PLUTO: Um, there is…

SATURN: Pluto! Shut up!

MARS: its okay, Pluto. We're all just objects floating in space. Nothing means anything.

SUN: Um… Mars, I… Anyway, back to the topic at hand… New business. Great. Okay. I called this meeting today because… well to be completely honest with all of you, I'm exhausted.

JUPITER: Exhausted?

SUN: Tired, Jupiter. I'm tired.

NEPTUNE: What?

SATURN: (yelling) Neptune, either move closer or just accept that you can't hear what's going on.

NEPTUNE: What?

SUN: Whatever. The point is I am tired and I need a vacation.

VENUS: Oh you poor baby… But, sunny honey, why on Earth are you so tired?

EARTH: Did someone say my name?

MERCURY: Idiomatic phrasing.

EARTH: What have I told you guys about doin' that?!

URANUS: Yeah, guys, we have no *earthly* business abusing her name like that. Get it? Get it?

SUN: Uranus, that wasn't even funny. It was just awkward. Come on. Can we please focus on me for like a minute!?

SATURN: Oh, because revolving around you isn't enough. By the way you talk, you would think that you are the center of the universe!

URANUS: Don't worry, Sun. "Galileo Galilei" over here is just jealous.

SUN: Guys, this is actually really important. I am going on vacation. I'm just going to do it. Probably head out to the Andromeda Galaxy for a little rest.

MARS: Rest. To die, to sleep… no more… It's not going to help. Nothing helps. We sleep and we eventually have to wake up and face our own existence.

VENUS: Why do we even invite Mars? Gives me the creeps. But I could change him…

MARS: What does it matter? We go in circles. Nothing changes. Nothing ever changes.

SUN: The point is that I need someone to take my place while I'm gone. Someone has to be the center of the solar system, right? Right. I'll only be gone for a little while, so it won't be that much of a time commitment.

JUPITER: Wait, so… you're leaving and we're going to need someone to be you for a while?

SUN: Yep, that's… That's exactly it. Good job Jupiter.

JUPITER: See, I'm smart.

SATURN: (sarcastically) Yeah, and humans landed on Earth's moon.

EARTH: It happened! It did!

SATURN: I still think you're making it up.

EARTH: I'll make you up!

NEPTUNE: What?

SUN: (yelling) Just go to sleep, Neptune!

VENUS: I still don't get why you have to leave.

SUN: Do you realize how exhausting it is being me? I never get to sleep because, well, I'm the sun. It's always bright. And hot. I have to keep my gravity pretty constant so you guys don't spin off into oblivion, and I have very little company except for Mercury and he never stops talking.

MERCURY: I didn't realize that you thought I…

SUN: (exasperated) Shh. Just… Shh…

URUNAS: Couldn't you, ya know, sleep at night?

SUN: Hilarious.

JUPITER: I don't get it.

EARTH: He's the sun, Jupiter. He doesn't have a night.

SUN: I am leaving. I am going on vacation and I am going to get some well-deserved sleep. That's that. The real purpose of this meeting is to tell all of you this and to tell you that one of you is going to have to take my place.

URANUS: Oh, I get it, I get it. I humbly accept the position. Thank you, thank you. As my first act as leader-

SATURN: Oh, that's funny, that's hysterical.

URANUS: That one wasn't a joke.

SATURN: I'm not laughing. You really think you can take care of the solar system by yourself, Uranus? You barely make acceptable puns.

EARTH: Oh, snap!

PLUTO: I think…

ALL: Shut up Pluto!

EARTH: I know how to solve all this. I think that I should be in charge.

MERCURY: You?

EARTH: They don't call me Mother Earth for nothing. I'm all for nurturin' and lovin' and takin' care of people.

VENUS: Oh, please. You? You can't even take care of yourself.

EARTH: Excuse me?

VENUS: Global warming?

EARTH: Climate change! Climate. Change. It is different.

SATURN: Denial. Regardless of what you call it, it is clear that I should be in charge.

MARS: Clothes don't make the man.

SATURN: Crazy planet says what?

MARS: Your many rings do not equate to power.

SATURN: Someone better make him shut up.

MERCURY: Don't you think that if we had that ability we would have already implemented it?

JUPITER: …I don't know what's going on.

EARTH: Do you ever know what's going on?

VENUS: Sunny, you can't just go on vacation. We obviously can't handle this. Not without you...

SUN: No, no, guys, it'll be totally fine. I've figured it out. Jupiter is massive. He should be able to keep all of you guys in orbit while I'm gone.

JUPITER: Uh… what?

VENUS: Oh, not this guy. He's cute and all… but dumb as a rock.

NEPTUNE: What?

EARTH: Ignore him. Just ignore him.

JUPITER: Uh… what is going on? Why am I the Sun?

SUN: No, we did the calculations and it… it works. I swear. It should be fine, right Mercury?

MERCURY: Well, fine is a relative term.

SUN:… What?

MERCURY: It doesn't… quite work out.

SUN: Mercury. You said it worked. You said I could go. I made plans to go. Away. From here.

MERCURY: I made a mistake?

SUN: A mistake?! Well… can we… what about one of the other stars?

MERCURY: They're too far away. Plus I don't think we want to mess up the constellations like that, do we?

SUN: But… but…

URANUS: I guess a vacation wasn't ever *in the stars* for you, man. Get it? Get it?

SATURN: We always get it!

URANUS: You never laugh…

VENUS: I laugh.

MARS: Humor is all relative. Funny doesn't matter. Laughing now? Who cares. In ten thousand years-

PLUTO: Shut up, Mars! Shut up everyone!

JUPITER: Woah. Was that Pluto?

EARTH: Oh, snap! What just happened up in here?!

PLUTO: Look, it's not my fault I'm not a planet anymore, alright guys? But I am still a part of this solar system and I should still have representation. Now Sun, I think it isn't fair that you can't take a vacation. But it is also true that we need you. We don't work well together without you. As for the rest of you, it didn't used to be like this. We used to get along. We used to be a solar system. Now what are we? We're just a bunch of rocks, floating along, with no regards for each other's feelings. I'm ashamed. Of all of you. I used to be proud to be a part of this system. But now… I'm glad I'm not. But we can change that. We just need to go back to what made us great in the first place: a common gravitational pull to this guy right here. And that is one of the strongest bonds of all.

JUPITER: That was beautiful.

SATURN: Yeah, uh, yeah. Well said, Pluto.

VENUS: Pluto, I know you're not a planet anymore, but I just want you to know… You'll always be a planet to me.

SUN: Look, guys, I'm sorry that I was going to abandon you all. I just get so stressed sometimes I could super nova.

EARTH: (*gasps)* We never knew you felt like this!

MERCURY: You can't leave things like that bottled up! No wonder your percentage of solar flares has dramatically increased!

SUN: No, but, after what Pluto just said, I realize there is no place I would rather be than right here.

NEPTUNE: What?

SUN: (yelling) I said I'm staying, you deaf old geezer!

NEPTUNE: Good!

VENUS: Sunny, we all know how you feel. We all could use a change sometimes.

SATURN: Yeah, but change comes in the most unexpected of places. Who knows? Maybe a black hole will form just outside the galaxy. Maybe we'll discover that space isn't infinite and at the edge there is a sign that says "dead end" or something! Maybe we'll discover life on Mars at some point.

MARS: Life is meaningless.

SATURN: Or maybe not. Probably not.

EARTH: And maybe, when Haley's Comet comes back around in a couple years, we can throw a big party.

URANUS: You know how you throw a space party? You planet. Get it? Get it?

JUPITER: (laughing ridiculously) I get it! I get it!

PLUTO: Um, guys?

MERCURY: Yes, Pluto?

PLUTO: I just wanted to say thank you… for inviting me.

SUN: I mean, who cares what those folks at NASA think, anyway? It's not like Earth has the last say in everything.

EARTH: Aw no, child. Those people down there still think my moon is made of green cheese.

MERCURY: Uh, I don't think anyone thinks that anymore.

VENUS: Oh look guys! A shooting star! Everyone make a wish.

MARS: (surprisingly optimistic) I don't have anything I want to wish for.

SUN: Me neither, Mars. Me neither.

END PLAY